

RANJAN RAHI

- Company: **JhaJi**
- Founders: **Kalpana Jha** (in red left) and **Uma Jha**
- When: **2020**
- Where: **Darbhanga, Bihar**
- Business: **Range of pickles**
- FY 2023 turnover: **₹3.5 crore**

the women to manage household chores while overseeing the business operations. "Bihar is still a conservative state and women venturing out to run their businesses is still uncommon," she says.

Though it had taken Kalpana five decades to plunge into entrepreneurship, the timing proved to be perfect. With social media aiding promotions and the easy access to digital payment options and e-commerce platforms like Amazon and Flipkart blurring retail boundaries, small businesses like Kalpana's found the opportunity to tap into a wider customer base. Reality business shows like *Shark Tank India*, the first season of which went on air in December 2021, and the Narendra Modi government's push for local businesses under the 'Vocal for Local' initiative have also helped build a conducive environment for Indian entrepreneurs. While Kalpana experimented with recipes to churn out bottles of delectable pickles, her marketing wizard son helped her launch a website in June 2021, for online sales. There's been no looking back for Kalpana since. Their sales doubled every month, reaching a turnover of Rs 1 crore in the very first year, says the happy businesswoman.



PAWAN BHAWAR

- Company: **Carragreen**
- Founders: **Surabhi Shah** (above) and **Chetna Shah**
- When: **2018**
- Where: **Indore**
- Business: **Ecofriendly packaging and stationery**
- FY 2023 turnover: **₹25 lakh**



"Home-based businesses are interesting because they work on an asset-light model, have significantly lower mortality rates and are usually profitable from day one"

- SAIREE CHAHAL
Founder chairperson, Mahila Money

Home-based enterprises—those operated from one's residence or adjacent premises—have traditionally served as a crucial source of livelihood for women. The scenario is still much the same in rural areas, where home-based businesses continue to be skill-oriented and related to traditional sectors such as handicrafts, handloom, food processing or pottery. Women's self-help groups (SHGs) created under the Centre's National Rural Livelihood Mission, state initiatives and by NGOs, work extensively to integrate these women into larger value chains and create sustainable setups. According to data from the Economic Survey 2022-23, India has around 12 million SHGs, 88 per cent of them all-women ones.

For urban women like Kalpana, however, home-based businesses are less a means to supplement the family income and more a fulfillment of their aspirations. The nature of these women-run home businesses has also undergone a makeover in urban areas, venturing beyond the traditional pickle-papad-making, beauty salons, clothes boutiques, food catering services and tuition centres into unexplored territories like manufacturing ayurvedic skin and beauty care products, disposable crockery and cutlery and eco-friendly stationery.

According to a 2020 report '(In)visible Entrepreneurs' by the Institute for What Works to Advance Gender Equality (IWWAGE) at Krea University in Sri City, Andhra Pradesh, a staggering 78 per cent of the 800 home-based women entrepreneurs surveyed in Rajasthan and Tamil Nadu expressed their desire to expand by broadening their market